

Stewards of the Springs: Program Snapshot (2026 Pilot)

Program Overview:

Stewards of the Springs is a regional stewardship initiative designed to protect natural hot springs across the West through education, visitor engagement, and measurable on-the-ground action. The program provides land managers with a low-impact, scalable system that improves visitor behavior, reduces visitor impact, and builds a culture of shared responsibility.

Why This Matters:

Natural hot springs are fragile, heavily visited, and often lack consistent staffing or infrastructure. Increasing visitation and social-media exposure have accelerated site degradation, litter, user conflict, and unsanitary conditions. Most of the impact and most of the care comes from visitors themselves.

Stewards of the Springs fills a critical gap by giving visitors clear guidance, tools, and recognition to support long-term site health.

How the Program Works:

- **Educational Signage**
Site-specific signage communicates etiquette, safety, Leave No Trace, and digital Leave No Trace (responsible non-geotagging).
- **QR-Based Stewardship Check-Ins**
Visitors log stewardship actions (trash pack-out, site care, issue reporting). Works offline and uploads when service returns.
- **Digital Leave No Trace**
The program reframes responsible non-geotagging as an act of stewardship rather than gatekeeping — shifting the cultural narrative around location sharing on social media. Built-in safeguards ensure the program itself does not contribute to social media exposure of sensitive sites.
- **Sticker & Reward System**
Each spring has a unique emblem (“Stamp of Stewardship”). Visitors earn stickers and progress through seven reward tiers.

- **Data Collection & Reporting**

Stewardship data is shared with land managers to identify high-use areas, maintenance needs, and emerging issues.

- **Community Engagement**

Partnerships with nonprofits, schools, and recreation groups promote responsible recreation and shared stewardship culture.

Pilot Launch (2026–2027):

Tentative Initial Sites (9):

- Goldbug (ID) – Contacted land manager, awaiting response
- Kirkham (ID) – Contacted land manager, awaiting response
- Trail Creek (ID) – Contacted land manager, awaiting response
- Weir (ID) – In communication with land manager
- Hart (OR) – In communication with land manager
- Umpqua (OR) – Contacted land manager, awaiting response
- Kyle (NV) – Private landowner, letter sent, awaiting response
- Renova (MT) – Private landowner, letter sent, awaiting response
- One additional site selected with partners and agency input.

Timeline:

- Spring 2026: Fiscal sponsorship secured; grant applications submitted, in-kind partnerships and donations established
- Summer–Fall 2026: Signage installation + program launch
- 2027: Data reporting, evaluation, expansion planning

Organizational Capacity:

Founder Lydia Anders brings interagency wildland fire experience (Washington State Helitack), park ranger experience, a degree in Natural Resource Enterprise Management from the University of Idaho, and years of hot springs stewardship knowledge. She designed the signage system, QR workflow, website, logo, stickers/graphics, reward tiers, data model, and has prepared the program for agency review.

Year 1 Budget:

Total: \$102,958

Includes signage, stewardship materials, visitor engagement tools, travel, and modest full-time, multi-state founder compensation (\$65,000) to ensure stable leadership during the pilot year.

What We're Seeking:

- Fiscal sponsorship to enable immediate grant eligibility
- Support in early grant strategy and review
- Partnership alignment for a 9-site pilot launch across the Western US

Stewards of the Springs is ready for implementation and positioned for scalable, long-term stewardship impact.